

Labububot

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Abstract. Social robots are designed to be emotionally unambiguous — cute, friendly, frictionless. However, monster theory reframes the uncanny valley as productive territory. Labububot is a deliberately monstrous social robot, embedded in living popular culture and fashion. We propose that robots which provoke rather than placate may foster deeper, genuine long-term engagement. For technical details please see our Github repository: <https://github.com/mirandali707/labububot>.



Fig. 1. Labububot in its natural habitat. Please see <https://tinyurl.com/labububot-video> for a video.

The design of social robots has strong norms: cute, or anthropomorphic, or both. Robots that look like babies are less threatening and more trustworthy [2, 6]. Anthropomorphism increases purchase intent [7], persuasiveness [1], and forgiveness [11]. But, as robots approach human-likeness, our affinity for them increases until the "uncanny valley" — a range of somewhat-but-not-quite-human features which instead trigger a distinct sense of unease [8]. The standard response to the uncanny valley is to design around it — to make robots cute enough, anthropomorphic enough, but not too much. The result is robots designed to feel frictionless: agreeable, legible, and emotionally unambiguous.

But monster theory suggests an alternative. Monster theory is an interdisciplinary field that studies monsters as cultural phenomena — not merely as fictional villains, but as symbols that reveal what a society fears, desires, and cannot categorize [3]. Scholar Jeffrey Cohen posits that a monster, by definition, resists classification, occupying spaces between human and animal, living and dead [3]. This is, of course, exactly what the uncanny valley describes [8]. The robot that triggers unease is not failing to be human — it is succeeding at being monstrous: a form that refuses easy categorization and demands engagement. Monsters are ubiquitous across cultures and throughout history precisely because they do not resolve; they are among our most durable pedagogical tools, probes for exploring complicated personal, social, and ethical questions [4, 5]. Rather than designing around

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emotional ambiguity, we might design into it instead. A robot that inhabits its own strangeness, rather than disguising it, can function not as a toy to be accepted, but as a provocation to be engaged.

Enter Labububot. Labububot takes its form from Labubu, a figure released by Pop Mart under the aptly-named product line "The Monsters". Labubu already inhabits the threshold that most social robots are designed to avoid: it is simultaneously cute and unsettling, a creature that grins with too many teeth and sits just outside the register of the purely adorable. It is also a genuine cultural phenomenon [10], circulating through global fashion culture with a resonance that no amount of engineered warmth has yet managed to produce in a social robot. Labububot takes this figure and pushes it further. Twelve Labubu heads are decapitated and reconstituted into an actuating spherical dodecahedron — an act of collage that pays deliberate homage to Frankenstein [9], that original monster assembled from parts, and that produces something categorically new: less anthropomorphic, more excessive, resistant to the affective resolution that a single cute face would provide. The design is intentionally confusing. Where conventional social robots manage affect — deploying baby schema to produce trust, compliance, and comfort — Labububot provokes it, inviting a more unsettled and therefore more reflective encounter. This is the argument made physical: Labububot is a social robot designed to lean into monstrosity. Labububot questions what social connection means, what we project onto the machines we build, and what the monsters we make reveal about the monsters we are.

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